EGLUTĖ TRINKAUSKAITĖ

Maryland Institute College of Art

ELLEN B. CUTLER

Independent Scholar

BALTIC RELIGION: THE SACRED THINGS

Abstract

In this chapter, I expand on the most vibrant traditional Baltic practices discussed in the Mapping the Doctrine of Discovery podcast and in my earlier work on edible mushroom gathering, sacred dimensions of wood, and the significance of beekeeping traditions (Trinkauskaitė 2008; 2019). Subjects include polyphonic songs called *sutartinės*, and traditional homesteads and their attendant deities. Baltic and Prussian domestic gods were believed to live with humans -- in cellars, granaries, and barns, lurking in corners or behind a stove. Relationships with spirits and divinities often define home. Ethnomusicologists emphasize the egalitarian nature of polyphonic singing. In their rhetorical and performative strategy, *sutartinės* are similar to the Haudenosaunee Thanksgiving Address. Their modern resurgence signals the urgent need for more collective consensus in a society that values individualism and hierarchical social structures.

Keywords**:** *Lithuania; Baltic religion; Baltic revival; Baltic crusades; polyphonic songs sutartinės; domestic spirits; Teutonic Knights*

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The Baltic Crusades: The People versus the Monastic Machine

The main goal of the Baltic or Northern crusades in Livonia (currently Latvia and Estonia), Prussia, and Lithuania was to convert local populations from Indigenous religious traditions to Christianity. For the military-religious Teutonic Order, missionary efforts were "an excuse to acquire land and riches"[1] from resource-rich frontier regions.

The Teutonic Order,[2] founded in 1190 as a religious and military society by German merchants in the port city of Acre in modern Israel, quickly grew in numbers and territory. By 1250 there were twelve bailiwicks, or discrete areas under their authority, in Germany and around the Mediterranean region. Where the knight-brothers held land, they reaped recruits, through conversion and feudal privilege. By the 14th century the Teutonic Order had around 2000 knight-brothers and 3000 priests, nuns, and sergeants.[3] The Teutonic knight-brothers were expected to kill, intimidate, and govern—all for the advancement of Christianity.[4]

The primary objective of strict military and monastic discipline was efficiency, though a few diversions were permitted. One such amusement was the craft of wood-carving. The knights could also hunt wolves and bears.[5] "In the course of the Lithuanian Reisen,[6] the Order organized hunts as centerpieces of the courtly activities it facilitated for aristocrats in the north. Aristocratic pastimes like hunting and feasting took on an especially masculine form in the Baltic, since women were forbidden from joining the Knights' crusades.[7] Scholars Kaarina Kailo and Barbara Alice Mann observe the absence of women in such activities, ceremonials that celebrate "male initiation into bravery, the skills of the hunt, and the killing of the bear."[8] Raiding expeditions like the Lithuanian Reisen conflated hunting and killing sports—"all that men are able to make from blood"[9] —and contrasted them with women's ability to create life. In their crusade against non-Christians, the Teutonic Knights raped women and acquired them as booty.[10] Were the Knights protecting the purity of their women from witnessing the violence they inflicted on Baltic women? As Mann and Kailo put it, "tales of female transgression and male 'rescue' of 'pure' womanhood under patriarchal family values shows the upshot of the raids visited on

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[1] Mark Cartwright, "Northern Crusades," World History Encyclopedia, 2018, https://www.worldhistory.org/Northern_Crusades/.

[2] Britannica, "Teutonic Order: Medieval Military & Religious Order," 2017, https://www.britannica.com/topic/Teutonic-Order.

[3] Eric Christiansen, *The Northern Crusades*, with Internet Archive (Penguin Education, 1997), 84, http://archive.org/details/northerncrusades00eric.

[4] Christiansen, *The Northern Crusades*, 88.

[5] Christiansen, *The Northern Crusades*, 87.

[6] Wikipedia, "Battle of Reisen," in *Wikipedia Encyclopedia*, January 1, 2025, https://en.wikipedia.org/w/index.php?title=Battle_of_Reisen&oldid=1266641888.

[7] Patrick Meehan, "A Promised Wilderness: Colonial Encounters and Landscape in the Late Medieval Baltic" (Doctoral Thesis, Harvard University Graduate, 2021), https://nrs.harvard.edu/URN-3:HUL.INSTREPOS:37368389.

[8] Barbara Alice Mann and Kaarina Kailo, *The Woman Who Married the Bear: The Spirituality of the Ancient Foremothers* (Oxford Academic, 2023), 136, https://academic.oup.com/book/55318.

[9] Mann and Kailo, *The Woman Who Married the Bear: The Spirituality of the Ancient Foremothers*, 136.

[10] Christiansen, *The Northern Crusades*, 88.

matriculture by Bronze Age violence."[11] Sandy Bigtree (Mohawk) points to patterns of violence established in these early forays that continued among the Jesuits in North America: "I know with the Jesuits coming into the northeast and the Woodland territories, they went right to the heart of the women. The women were resistant in fighting, to maintain and hold on to their matrilineal associations to Mother Earth. It's terrifying."[12]

The Teutonic Knights plundered Prussia and Lithuania for natural and human resources, although their laws prohibited the taking of Christian slaves.[13] Historian Patrick Meehan describes the Order taking Lithuanian captives from the "rich, well-settled land."[14] The Teutonic Order valued indigenous peasants as laborers, and especially "for their ability to walk through a landscape that caused constant frustration to baggage trains."[15] Lithuania's thick forests "full of swamps, bogs, marshy lakes and rivers"[16] presented significant challenges for travelers. The peasants knew the best routes and how to navigate the local terrain. The Order used indigenous knowledge to amass wealth in a process that Anna Tsing describes as salvage accumulation: "The conversion of indigenous knowledge into capitalist returns is salvage accumulation."[17]

Local people and cattle were also part of that "salvage accumulation." In Reisen's journey through the Baltic wilderness, local people and cattle were common spoils. Peter Suchewirt (c. 1320-1395), Austrian poet and herald, described Samogitia (the western region of modern Lithuania) as "so full of people and resources, that we had whatever we wanted; what was gained for the Christians was the pagans' loss."[18] Wegenerichte, the Teutonic Order's navigational reports, described plundering routes through the Baltic landscape in detail.[19] The Baltic wildnis was not so much "an unpopulated region but a depopulated one after a century of warfare bent on leeching the region of its riches and displacing its population."[20] Teutonic historians lump "pagans and wild beasts" together and point to "the primeval affinity between indigenous people and lands as a threatening, even sinister, obstacle to the cultivation of a productive Christian society."[21] The Order perceived the Baltic wilderness as the Promised Land and indigenous people living there as an obstacle.[22] "Language recurring throughout the history conveys the wild, even monstrous, disposition of Indigenous rivals, pushing Nicolaus's hunting metaphors beyond an entertaining narrative motif for battle scenes to a dehumanizing discourse. Nor do Nicolaus's hunted pagans seem to share in the tragically valiant traits commonly ascribed to the heart in stylized literary depictions of its pursuit. Similar to Wigand's descriptions of defeated

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[11] Mann and Kailo, *The Woman Who Married the Bear: The Spirituality of the Ancient Foremothers*, 136.

[12] Adam DJ Brett, *S03E04: Beekeeping, Mushrooms and Sculptures: A Glimpse into Traditional Lithuanian Life with Eglutė Trinkauskaitė*, episode 3, with Philip P Arnold and Sandra Bigtree, Mapping the Doctrine of Discovery, n.d., 2023, 56:11, accessed April 3, 2025, https://podcast.doctrineofdiscovery.org/season3/episode-04/.

[13] Meehan, "A Promised Wilderness," 232.

[14] Ibid, 233.

[15] Ibid," 232.

[16] Eglutė Trinkauskaitė, "Seeing the Swarming Dead: Of Mushrooms, Trees, and Bees" (Doctoral Thesis, Syracuse University, 2008), https://www.lituanistika.lt/content/100255.

[17] Anna Lowenhaupt Tsing, *The Mushroom at the End of the World* (Princeton University Press, 2015), 63–64, https://press.princeton.edu/books/paperback/9780691220550/the-mushroom-at-the-end-of-the-world.

[18] Meehan, "A Promised Wilderness," 330.

[19] Ibid, 295.

[20] Ibid, 306.

[21] Ibid, 142.

[22] Steven T Newcomb, *Pagans in the Promised Land: Decoding the Doctrine of Christian Discovery* (Fulcrum Publishing, 2008), https://books.google.com.pk/books/about/Pagans_in_the_Promised_Land.html?id=HeDKUXsOC9cC&redir_esc=y.

Lithuanians, Nicolaus's pagans are terrified, panicked, and humiliated when he compares them to hunted animals."[23]

Beyond the Germanic stereotypes of Prussia, and Lithuania in particular, the Teutonic Order saw wilderness as "intrinsic to their portrayal of Baltic culture."[24] The Teutonic historians did not represent the Baltic people as a cohesive society but as "scattered hunters, fishers, and beekeepers roving elusively through the foliage of the forests and through the folios of the archival records."[25] Reducing indigenous inhabitants to beasts, they understood their task as the exploitation of the region's people and natural resources through the unavoidable deployment of violence.[26]

Spiritual Rewards

The monastic brothers knew that whatever they did, their earthly sins would be forgiven. "Pope Eugenius III (r. 1145-1153) officially declared that the first Baltic Crusade would, like that in the Middle East, earn its combatants a remission of sins."[27] The Teutonic Knights participated in such dubious activities as fortune telling and divination using animal bones. It is thought that most Teutonic Knights were Christian converts from paganism, since "the Order, dating from the mid-thirteenth century, placed no particular restrictions on recruitment."[28] As the Order grew, recruitment became less discriminating. Though "the ideal knight Brother, requested in Prussia as well as in Livonia, was a young, healthy and fit nobleman" (Militzer 1994). Most Teutonic Knights, however, were recruited from social circles very close to traditional culture, and as a result their closeness to pre-Christian values and mythology cannot be ruled out."[29] In other words, freshly recruited monastic soldiers had a similar peasant background to unconverted Baltic peoples.

Though the Brothers' official religion was Christian, some of their everyday practices were observed to be pagan.[30] As early as 1305, the Archbishop of Riga and the City of Riga (the two key political adversaries of the Teutonic Knights in Livonia) formally accused the Teutonic Knights before the Papal Curia of 230 counts of practicing pagan rites.[31] The practice of fortune telling "closely resembled the local traditions of the Baltic peoples"[32] according to the testimony of a Cistercian monk, "a certain brother of the order of the said brothers of the Hospital, looking in the scapular bone of a certain pig, predicted to the other brothers certain future things that after that happened, as that brother foretold."[33] The authors of the Livonian Rhymed Chronicle, the 13th century "table book" of the Teutonic Knights, confirm the efficacy of divination and give credibility to a story of a captured pagan Lithuanian commander: "Meanwhile a strange thing occurred in Riga; as Lengewin sat at the table, eating with the brothers, he looked at a shoulder bone and his heart sank. He said, 'The Lithuanians are defeated. My brother has been killed. An army has been at

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[23] Meehan, "A Promised Wilderness," 145.

[24] Ibid, 146.

[25] Ibid, 303.

[26] Ibid, 301.

[27] Cartwright, "Northern Crusades."

[28] Kaspars Kļaviņš, "The Ideology of Christianity and Pagan Practice among the Teutonic Knights: The Case of the Baltic Region," *Journal of Baltic Studies* 37, no. 3 (2006): 271, https://doi.org/10.1080/01629770608628892.

[29] Kļaviņš, "The Ideology of Christianity and Pagan Practice among the Teutonic Knights," 276.

[30] Paulius Juodis, "Lithuania — The Last Pagan State in Europe," Medium, 2023, https://medium.com/illumination/a-short-history-of-lithuania-christianization-alliance-with-poland-partition-and-reemergence-daebaecc0026.

[31] Kļaviņš, "The Ideology of Christianity and Pagan Practice among the Teutonic Knights," 262.

[32] Ibid, 276.

[33] Ibid, 62.

my manor since yesterday.' Now bones have since lied to many man, but they did not lie to Lengewin."[34]

Burning the dead and killing their own critically wounded were among other accusations of non-Christian practices ascribed to the Teutonic Knights. "In light of Christian doctrine about the resurrection of the body, burning of the dead contravened the teachings of the medieval Catholic Church, and differences in funerary practices were often viewed as significant watersheds between 'Christianity' and 'paganism."[35]

Some Teutonic recruits were not that culturally different from the people they were charged to convert to Christianity. The knight-brothers, moreover, sometimes made offerings of weapons and horses, as did the Baltic non-Christians. After devastating Samogitian lands (Žemaitija) and taking "all the booty they could carry," the Teutonic Knights gave a part of their booty to their Christian God "because he had given them a safe journey. He had earned His share, and they gave Him weapons and horses."[36] Equine sacrifice was also a tradition in medieval Germany and the Teutonic Knights did not alter their own pre-Christian traditions after joining the Order, even to improve their social condition.[37] Historian Eric Christiansen argues that Christianity did not appeal to Lithuanians because Baltic "religion was successful in its own right"[38] as an effective political system based on reciprocity. The hierarchical structure of Christianity ultimately seemed unsatisfactory. While conversion was an option for many, the act was less a matter of metanoia than pragmatism. The Teutonic Knights, known for their brutality and greed, could not bully such numerous and far-flung peoples. The theology of the Catholic Church based in Rome did not appeal to the Lithuanians, a diverse and ecumenical society . Pre-Christian Lithuania, a prosperous nation, included Latins, Greeks, Jews and Tartars in a notably impartial system.[39]

Resistance to Christianization after 1386 indicated the presence of "a deep rooted and much-valued" native religion not reliant on the participation of economic and social elites who converted to advance their role in the political system increasingly oriented to the West.[40] Deloria points out that in North America, "what has been the manifestation of deity in a particular local situation is mistaken for truth applicable to all times and places, a truth so powerful that it must be impressed upon peoples who have no connection to the event or to the cultural complex in which it originally made sense."[41] One could reasonably compare the post-Columbian evangelizing efforts of Christians to the pressure exerted on Baltic non-Christian communities. Deloria describes the structure of indigenous religious traditions as "taken directly from the world around them, from their relationships with other forms of life. Context is therefore all-important for both practice and the understanding of reality."[42]

"You have been Signified"

A historian of religions, Charles H. Long used to say, "You have been signified." Signification is a textured art of obscuring, a power game in which language is the

[34] Ibid, 262.
[35] Ibid, 264.
[36] Ibid, 265.
[37] Ibid,266.
[38] Christiansen, *The Northern Crusades*, 145.
[39] Ibid,145.
[40] Ibid,, 145.
[41] Vine Deloria, *God Is Red: A Native View of Religion* (Fulcrum Publishing, 2003), 66.
[42] Deloria, *God Is Red*, 67.

instrument of subordination but it does not accept responsibility for doing so. There are many terms used to signify other Baltic peoples: "Lithuanian pagans," "pagans in the Baltic," "the stubbornly pagan Lithuanians."[43] "The Saracens of the North,"[44] and "the Balts of Prussia, Latvia, and Lithuania who still existed in early modern Europe."[45] The language of signification in missionary texts echo in secondary scholarship. We have only begun to recognize the distortions that signification imposes on our perceptions and understanding. Scholars now study the way that language functions in the subordination of peoples.

Superiority" and "subordination" are key concepts associated with Western exploration of the globe and European encounters with Indigenous peoples of other lands. These terms set the parameters of discourse on religion, identity, and territory. Significations constitute the texture of the way we judge cultures and set the relationships among peoples in the modern world.[46] Signification distorts the character and consequences of intellectual formulations about the myths, symbols, rituals, histories, and imaginations of groups other than one's own.[47]

The Sacred Things/Baltic religion

In light of this consideration of the impact of the Teutonic Knights in the Baltic region, and especially on the nature of the imposition of Roman Catholicism on the peoples of Lithuania in particular, there are interesting insights to be gained in the study of traditional Indigenous beliefs, practices, and arts. Efforts to revitalize and renew religio-cultural identity, then, occur within the contested realm of signification.[48] The members of that community define the sacred; those outside the community learn to act in response to that definition.[49]

The hermeneutical challenge, the matter of understanding and interpretation, of signification when it comes to Baltic religion, is that the thick signifying is disconnected from lived cultural practices. Scholars, for instance, produce descriptions and analyses of Lithuanian "paganism" but contemporary practitioners of Baltic religion call it "ancient Baltic religion." The word "pagan" is freighted with connotation. The Baltic community rejects being signified as "pagans," but some academicians insist on language they associate with such early authors as Peter of Dusburg (13th-14th century), a Teutonic chronicler. Through centuries of Christianization, and given the uncertain survival of oral traditions, much authentic understanding has been lost. Surviving fragments, however, offer material for new interpretations of Baltic traditions and an opportunity to reconstruct the Baltic religion.

In discussing a few of these traditions, I will first consider the revival of polyphonic songs--sutartinės--an ancient ceremonial practice.

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[43] Francis Young, "'Of Divels in Sarmatia Honored': Writing Baltic Paganism In Early Modern England," *Pomegranate* 24, no. 1 (2023): 89, https://doi.org/10.1558/pome.19468.

[44] Young, "'Of Divels in Sarmatia Honored,'" 72.

[45] Young, "'Of Divels in Sarmatia Honored,'" 72.

[46] Charles H Long, *Significations: Signs, Symbols, and Images in the Interpretation of Religion* (Fortress Press, 1986), 4, https://archive.org/details/significationssi0000long_c2f4.

[47] Carrasco Carrasco, "Introduction," in *Significations: Signs, Symbols, and Images in the Interpretation of Religion*, ed. Charles H Long (Fortress Press, 1986), https://archive.org/details/significationssi0000long_c2f4.

[48] Dennis F. Kelley, *Tradition, Performance, and Religion in Native America: Ancestral Ways, Modern Selves*, with Internet Archive (Routledge, 2014), 26, http://archive.org/details/traditionperform0000kell.

[49] Kelley, *Tradition, Performance, and Religion in Native America*, 26.

The Baltic Revival: Polyphonic Songs Sutartinės

Sutartinės have enjoyed a new popularity in the contemporary era. This is revitalization, renewal, and adaptation of one of the most ancient Baltic traditions. Polyphonic songs are a part of the oral tradition that survived eradication by Christian missionaries. In 2010, UNESCO included sutartinės as a part of Lithuania's intangible heritage.[50] Singing sutartinės joins voices in an "archaic vocal polyphony" that possibly dates back to Old Europe around the third millennium (BCE).[51] Contemporary Lithuanians sing sutartinės not only as "a spiritual exercise" but also as "the political act of self-identification" as Baltic people.[52] The name sutartinės derives from the Lithuanian verb sutarti, "to agree." Polyphony—"many sounds"—is a style of music focused on harmony in which voices sing individual melodies in unison. The spirit of polyphony is an "ethical and aesthetic" consensus where individual consciousness merges into a collective harmony.[53]

I see he group practice of singing sutartinės as comparable to the Chumash revival of canoe/tomol traditions, and in the "community-forming" efforts observed by Dennis Kelley in the pan Indian Indigenous revivals that revolve "around culturally specific activities such as dancing, storytelling, traditional arts and more.[54] All of these activities have religious connotations in their specific tribal contexts.[55]

Singing of sutartinės builds community in a fragmented world and offers enchantment in the modern day. "The archaic nature of sutartinės songs is shown not by individual features of their musical language, but by the totality of these features, the peculiarities of their poetics, and performance traditions."[56] A group of bičiulės ("Friends through Bees") call themselves Ūtara. The verb ūtaroti means to chit-chat or talk. Ūtara describes singing ancient polyphonic music in a group not simply as singing but as the nurturing of community gatherings which bring a deeper, meditative meaning to the fabric of everyday life. As one participant said, "After many years of delving into the nuances of traditional singing, expeditions to villages, listening to authentic recordings, we realized that it is sutartinės that unite us with their strange, monotonous sound, they soothe, comfort, caress like a song from a very distant past."[57]

They say, as well, that if they didn't sing polyphonic songs, they wouldn't be able to talk with each other so openly.[58]

Musical performance reflects the horizontal structure of social interrelations. Though specific tribal contexts have been lost in the Baltics, these revivals may be observed in the entire Baltic region as pan-Baltic efforts of cultural resurgence in the post-colonial, post-Soviet era. The pan-Baltic revival is a political and spiritual assertion of identity as well as an expression of cultural solidarity in the context of ongoing Russian aggression toward former Soviet states.

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[50] *Sutartines, Lithuanian Multipart Songs*, directed by Juozas Javaitis (UNESCO, 2010), Video, 600, https://www.unesco.org/archives/multimedia/document-1666.

[51] Eirimas Velička, "Lithuanian Polyphonic Songs Sutartinės: The Archaic Nature of Their Musical Language in the Context of Global Music," *Frontiers in Psychology* 15, no. 1 (2024): 1, https://doi.org/10.3389/fpsyg.2024.1285394.

[52] Kelley, *Tradition, Performance, and Religion in Native America*, 50.

[53] P G Coy, *Consensus Decision Making, Northern Ireland and Indigenous Movements: Vol. 24*, vol. 24 (JAI, 2003), https://www.emerald.com/insight/publication/doi/10.1016/s0163-786x(2002)24.

[54] Kelley, *Tradition, Performance, and Religion in Native America*, 41.

[55] Ibid, 33.

[56] Velička, "Lithuanian Polyphonic Songs Sutartinės," 1.

[57] Antakalniečių Community, "Contract singers' group 'Ūtara,'" *Association "Antakalniečių Community*, n.d., accessed April 3, 2025, https://www.antakalnieciai.lt/sutartiniu-giedotoju-grupe-utara/.

[58] Antakalniečių Community, "Contract singers' group 'Ūtara.'"

Ethnomusicologists emphasize the egalitarian nature of polyphonic singing – each voice being equally important. In their rhetorical and performative strategy, sutartinės are similar to the Haudenosaunee Thanksgiving Address in which the phrase "Now our minds are one" after each element of the natural world is thanked. Historian of religion Philip P. Arnold writes that "the Thanksgiving Address centers in the mind of the participants the importance of maintaining a balance with the natural world that surrounds the human world. The "Great Law of Peace" in Indigenous American groups works on consensus. Decisions must be achieved by complete agreement and, as such, achieving the unity of minds is critical for the success of any gathering."[59]

Researchers of sutartinės trace the archaic genre to women performers. The singers were sometimes imagined as Laumės (witches) singing songs while washing clothes at night by a lake. Lithuanian-American archeologist Marija Gimbutas (1921-1994) argued that the Laumės imagery—the old crone—is "an inversion or degradation of the Great Goddess."[60] Traditionally, women sang in small groups of two, three, or four.[61] In the old days, while pulling flax, the singers used to imitate instrumental sutartinės played on woodwind instruments, as if they were playing. "Women used to say: let's sing a sutartinė. And they sang – all four of them – as if they were playing."[62]

One-third of the sutartinės, these polyphonic songs, are work songs that in their performance structure emphasize the equality of each participating voice. Their modern resurgence might be due to the urgent need for more collective consensus in the modern society that values individualism and hierarchical social structures. According to the study of consensus in indigenous social movements, a collective approach "means not just sharing rights and rewards but also sharing equally the responsibilities and the problems."[63] In the working environment, absence of hierarchy emphasizes that each task is equally important, encouraging "a horizontal rather than a vertical distribution of power and knowledge."[64] Just like singing, working collectively is most effective in small groups. The singers of two-part sutartinės observe that their voices weave together in a similar way to weaving patterns, creating a sonic ornament. Some sutartinės imitate the sound of the flying cranes and other birds.[65] The rhythmic, repetitive weaving of music and language creates musilanguage – "a kind of syncretism between music and language."[66]

The constant repetition characteristic of sutartinės performance emphasizes cyclical rather than linear time, underlying their archaic origins.[67] Ethnomusicologists observe that some sutartinės, like other musical genres from ancient cultures, incorporate synchronized movement that reinforced social bonding. A choreography of walking in a circle often accompanies sutartinės and connects the songs to other rituals. For example, walking in a circle and bowing to the sun while singing in the evening is an archaic ritual honoring the setting sun.[68]

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[59] Philip P Arnold, "And Now Our Minds Are One," in *Native American Rhetoric*, ed. Lawrence W Gross (University of New Mexico Press, 2021), 30, https://www.ubcpress.ca/native-american-rhetoric.

[60] Velička, "Lithuanian Polyphonic Songs Sutartinės," 3.

[61] Velička, "Lithuanian Polyphonic Songs Sutartinės," 3.

[62] Austė Nakienė, "On Instrumental Origins of Lithuanian Polymodal 'Sutartinės,'" *Studia Musicologica Academiae Scientiarum Hungaricae* 44, no. 1/2 (2003): 159.

[63] Coy, *Consensus Decision Making, Northern Ireland and Indigenous Movements: Vol. 24*, 24:12.

[64] Ibid, 24:10.

[65] Velička, "Lithuanian Polyphonic Songs Sutartinės," 4–5.

[66] Ibid," 5.

[67] Ibid, 3.

[68] Ibid, 18.

Some of the movements contain "animistic and totemic" elements, such as the performance of goat-hopping, sparrow-limping steps, or a sparrow inviting an owl to dance and stepping on her foot. The goats are abundant in Lithuanian oral traditions, and some of the songs "relate to the autumn rite of sacrificing a goat."[69] Owls and bees are also significant themes. When examining the beaked Goddess-bird figurines from 5000-4500 BCE, Lithuanian-American archeologist Marija Gimbutas argued that "the Owl can be considered one of the most important attributes of the Great Goddess."[70]

The resurgence of sutartinės and other Indigenous oral traditions indicates decreasing reliance on the written word as the most effective mode of communication: "The human voice and the presence of interlocutors have found an extremely powerful ally in digital technology, one that no longer forces to rely solely upon the letters of the alphabet to transmit what we need to learn from or make known to others, and which allows us to use our natural communicative resources (eyes, ears, tongue, hand gestures, etc.) without the restriction of being physically present in a given place."[71]

Sutartinės brings people together, allowing them to communicate in physical, non-linear ways. Women's voices weave sonic ornaments, animating the connections with the natural world. through lyrics that personify the sun, the animals, and the trees.

Home is where the Pagirniai Are: Domestic Spirits in Lithuania

Baltic and Prussian domestic gods were believed to live with humans — in cellars, granaries, and barns, lurking in corners or behind a stove. For the residents of this region, home was often defined by relationships with spirits and divinities.

A Peasant's Home

The peasant dwelling place in sixteenth-century Lithuania—and for the next century or two—was little different from a barn and occasionally functioned as one. A travel narrative written by Zygmund (Sigismund von) Herberstein following his travels in Lithuania in 1517 and 1526 describes a typical home of a Samogitian[72] peasant: "They live in low and very long huts with a fireplaces. Sitting next to the fire, the head of the family can see the animals and all of the family property. They live with the animals under the same roof — there is no partition."[73]

Such a home was called a namas or numas in Samogitian. A namas had an opening in the gable for smoke and animal smells to escape. was rectilinear and the roof was often covered in hay. The windows were covered with greased paper or the stretched skin of an animal bladder. Many were comprised of a single living space although bigger houses had three rooms. The only furnishings were tables and benches, and people sat on the benches during the day and slept on them at night. Heat came from an open fireplace, or a wood-burning stove called a krosnis. Peasants cooked their food in hanging cauldrons or in tripod pots; some also used iron frying pans. Wealthier peasants had more cookware and dishes.

According to architectural historians, such houses were among the oldest types of buildings, conjoining cooking and living space for humans with stabling for farm animals.

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[69] Ibid, 4.

[70] Ibid, 4–5.

[71] Maurizio Bettini, *In Praise of Polytheism by Maurizio Bettini*, trans. Douglas Grant Heise (University of California Press, 2014), 109, https://www.ucpress.edu/books/in-praise-of-polytheism/hardcover.

[72] Wikipedia, "Samogitia," in *Wikipedia*, March 29, 2025, https://en.wikipedia.org/w/index.php?title=Samogitia&oldid=1282885726.

[73] Neringa Dambrauskaitė, "Details of the Peasants Everyday Life in the Grand Duchy of Lithuania in the 16th Century and the First Half of the 17th Century," *Lietuvos Istorijos Studijos* 46 (December 2020): 29, https://doi.org/10.15388/LIS.2020.46.2.

By the beginning of the eleventh century, such structures were widespread throughout Lithuania and the Baltic Sea region. During the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries namas was the standard dwelling for poor Samogitians. By then, wealthier people already used namas primarily for agricultural purposes; if they lived in them, it was generally during the warm summer weather.

Home Spirits: The Pagirniai

Pagirniai (singular: pagirnis) were collectively the domestic gods and required the attention of the residents. Men and women conducted ritual sacrifices separately. Men would sacrifice pigs and bulls three times a year, while women sacrificed roosters to their deity. A new wife becomes the head of the household only after sacrificing some bread and giving a towel to Pagirnis. Pagirniai are typically embodied in the form of a grass snake (tropidonotus natrix). The word pagirnis is related to ideas about a millstone (grinų akmuo) used to grind grain. A pagirnis, the spirit, is believed to live under a millstone behind a separate wooden partition. Such a locale was frequently home to a grass snake.

In Lithuania, a grass-snake was considered sacred.[74] Its ability to shed its skin and to grow a new one made it a material manifestation of the earth's regenerative powers. It was a guardian of the home and protection from thunderstorms, illnesses and other misfortunes. The Polish historian Jan Dlugosz (1415-1480) wrote how Lithuanians kept grass snakes and other snakes as sacred protectors of the home. Each home had a grass snake, and people sacrificed to them as deities.[75]

The appearance of a grass snake in one's yard was considered a lucky omen, and people gave it milk, honey, and eggs. Samogitians and other Lithuanians also invited grass snakes to eat at the table. The snakes would crawl up a clean linen cloth to the top of the table and taste various dishes. When they had dined, they slithered back down and returned to the house where they hid in cracks and crevices.[76]

Barns Are As Important As The Home

A barn was more than an outbuilding to house livestock. It was also a place of ritual practices intended to protect the family. Goat sacrifices to agricultural deities who were the source of prosperity, for instance, took place in a barn. In the sixteenth century, Polish printer and translator Jan Malecki (1490-1567), who had done considerable research but never traveled to Lithuania, described such an event. He said after inviting "these demons" to the barn, people gathered there, singing hymns to the sacrificial animal. After the sacrifice, they splattered the blood around the barn and gave the meat to the women to fry. Cooking and feasting all took place there. Women made patties from wheat flour which the men cooked by throwing them back-and-forth across the flames. Those gathered feasted all day and night. Early the following morning they buried the remains of the feast behind a house, safe from the depredations of birds and wild animals.[77]

The barn is also a place to feed Barstukai, small beings like Kaukai associated with places underground. Barstukai were thought to bring wealth; to attract them, people laid out supper in the evening, covering a table with a cloth and providing bread, butter, cheese,

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[74] Norbertas Vėlius, *Baltų Religijos Ir Mitologijos Šaltiniai. T. 2: Xvi Amžius* (The Science and Encyclopedia Publishers, 2001), 421, http://archive.org/details/baltu-religijos-ir-mitologijos-saltiniai-t.-2-2001.

[75] Vėlius, *Baltų Religijos Ir Mitologijos Šaltiniai. T. 2*, 311.

[76] Ibid,, 630.

[77] Vėlius, *Baltų Religijos Ir Mitologijos Šaltiniai. T. 2*, 208–9.

and beer. It sounds rather like a ploughman's lunch served in an English pub. An empty table in the morning was a good omen. It was a bad sign if the food had not been touched.[78]

Wealth: It's Not Like Building Equity Today

In Lithuania, love and respect for wood is evident everywhere. Wood, moreover, was the only available material for building a namas or a barn or a church. In addition to a home and barn, a European peasant homestead might include a granary and a workshop for some specialized craft. A wealthy peasant's homestead could have as many as eight to ten buildings.[79] Though wealthier homesteads had fences and gates, violent robberies were common. Often, dogs were used to protect the property. The granary was of such signal value that a statute in the sixteenth century made stealing the contents of another peasant's granary a capital offense. The punishment was death by hanging.

In such an environment, fire was an omnipresent danger. Wealth accrued slowly and painfully over generations could be wiped out in a matter of hours. A court case documenting the arson of the homestead of Simonas Nožčičius emphasizes the importance of the granary, the repository of all of a peasant's wealth. Other forms of material and agricultural wealth were part of the infrastructure belonging to Nožčičius, and were carefully inventoried: thirty beehives, a shed with three wheels, a garden with cabbage, cucumbers, and garlic. The fire also consumed thirty chickens and five geese.[80]

Defense Against Loss

Because the fire was especially destructive to the property, there was a need to worship the fire god. One might interpret fire deities as protectors — not as emergency fire departments. Ublanyčia is the spirit associated with a threshing barn (jauja) — a separate building also used for baking bread and cooking. While this spirit belongs to the fire gods, its name comes from the same root as a vat or large container (Kubilnyčius, from kubilas). Ublanyčia is also charged with protecting domestic wealth from thieves.[81]

Dimstipatis, the Lithuanian god of homesteads and fire, first appears in the Jesuit Stamislavas Rustovkis' 1583 report. There are various beliefs about Dimstipatis — some say that he is a fire god, others believe that he protects homes from fires. This fire protection service required humans to enter into a contract of mutual obligations with Dimstipatis.

There are enough descriptions of sacrifices to Dimstipatis to confirm support that he protected homes. Jesuits described sacrifices of roosters and pigs by local people to this home deity.[82] After cooking a rooster, people ate the meat and threw the bones into the fire for him.

Others believe that Dimstipatis is the mother of the family. Mothers join together to sacrifice a pig, surrounding the animal so that the oldest one may slaughter it. The sacrifice is followed by a meal of the meat.[83]

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[78] Ibid.

[79] Dambrauskaitė, "Details of the Peasants Everyday Life in the Grand Duchy of Lithuania in the 16th Century and the First Half of the 17th Century," 27.

[80] Ibid.

[81] Carlo Ginzburg and Bruse Lincoln, *Old Thiess, a Livonian Werewolf: A Classic Case in Comparative Perspective* (University of Chicago Press, 2020), https://press.uchicago.edu/ucp/books/book/chicago/O/bo46813477.html.

[82] Beresnevičius Gintaras, *Trumpas lietuvių ir prūsų religijos žodynas* (Tyto Alba, 2019), https://www.hubris.lt/preke/gintaras-beresnevicius-trumpas-lietuviu-ir-prusu-religijos-zodynas/.

[83] Vėlius, *Baltų Religijos Ir Mitologijos Šaltiniai. T. 2*, 630.

Home Is What You Own

For the Lithuanian peasant, for hundreds of years, prosperity was a matter of material property. The specificity of possessions can appear obsessive to the modern eye but survival and a defense against drought, harvest failure, fire and other disasters depended on these things.

A detailed inventory of a wealthy peasant's material property appears in a court case in 1636. A peasant Jonas Petravičius and his family ran away from his master and took the following wealth with them. The first category on the inventory specified farm animals: one light-colored filly (cost two kapas); four bulls for roughing (four-five kapas); two cows (three-four kapas); nine old sheep; four old goats; four pigs; two hogs; five geese; seven hens; eight roosters; two calves. The second category is grain: nine barrels of rye; two-three barrels of wheat; two barrels of barley; two-three barrels of spring crops; eight barrels of oats; four barrels of buckwheat; 1,5 barrels of beans; 0,5 barrel of flaxseed; 1/4 barrel of hemp. The third category is various fabrics and items of clothing: fur coats; shawls; linen cloth; and wool yarn. The next section lists objects used for food storage: three pails for storing vegetables; oak barrels for making beer; two barrels of beer, etc. Then come the tools: two scythes; four sickles; two axes; millstones; two pitchforks. Finally, there are more clothes: two hats decorated with fox fur; four men's linen shirts; six women's shirts; women's cloaks; and many other things.[84]

Conclusion

This has been a brief introduction to the means that preserved traditional Baltic culture and religion, especially in the face of assertive efforts to convert all the people to Christianity, particularly by representatives of the Catholic Church in Rome. That as much information about peasant life, habits of worship, and shared music has survived is remarkable. It is a testament to the profound embrace of the life and culture that flowered in the years prior to 1387.

[84] Dambrauskaitė, "Details of the Peasants Everyday Life in the Grand Duchy of Lithuania in the 16th Century and the First Half of the 17th Century," 39–40.